



ZULUS

DURING THE REIGN OF KING SHAKA (1816-1823), Zulus became the mightiest military force in southern Africa. This small group conquered and absorbed many other tribes, resulting in a fifty-fold increase in the land they

MODERN LIVES, TRADITIONAL WISDOM

Health and illness

Zulus believe bad luck, ill health, and death can often be attributed to sorcery or an offended spirit. The first step when a problem is suspected is to consult an *isangoma*. These healers, almost all of them women, feel called to their profession. They undergo intensive and lengthy training while apprenticed to an experienced practitioner.



UMUTI MARKET

While an *isangoma* diagnoses ill health and divines the reason for it, a specialist called an *inyanga* makes up and administers *umuti*—Zulu medicines. These are made of plant and animal products and many Zulus prefer them to Western medicines.

An *isangoma* carries an *ishoba*—a stick made with the tail of a wildebeest and decorated with beads—as an aid to diagnosis.

Isangomas wear distinctive beadwork in their hair.

